

FINANCES

Prosperity is God's plan for you. 2 Corinthians 9:8 says, *"And God is able to make all grace abound toward you, that you, always having all sufficiency in all things, have an abundance for every good work."* Psalms 1:1-3 tells you that because you delight yourself in the Word, everything that you do will prosper. Proverbs 10:22 says, *"The blessing of the Lord makes one rich, and He adds no sorrow to it."*

God's will is for you to prosper in every area of your life. But God's will can only come to pass as you believe His Word and stand in faith. You and your future spouse must be in agreement with the Word, and you will reap the fruit of it.

In this lesson on finances, we will cover several areas that you need to think about and discuss with each other. The areas we will cover are unity in finances, tithing, spending habits and budget.

As in every other area, unity is very important in your finances. If you do not have unity, you will have division, strife, and confusion. To build unity, you must see the finances as 'ours', not 'his/hers' and 'mine'. You will not have unity if there is secrecy; therefore, open communication is very important.

Discuss and answer the following questions:

1. What outstanding debts do you have?

2. What plan do you have to pay off these debts (if there are any)?

3. Is your income, or combined income, enough to meet all of your financial obligations?

4. Who will be responsible for the chequebook, bookkeeping, bill-paying, etc.?

5. Write down, then discuss, your thoughts about separate checking accounts.

An extremely important principle that must be understood in the area of finances is tithing. 'Tithe' means 'a tenth part of one's annual income'. You must understand that tithing is an important and valuable principle from the Word of God that will bring blessings into your life. Malachi 3: 10 says, *"Bring all the tithe into the storehouse, and prove Me now in this," says the Lord of Hosts, "If I will not open for you the windows of heaven and pour out for you such blessing that there will not be room enough to receive it."* Tithing should be an integral part of a believer's life. A person will put his money where his heart is; therefore, your priority investment should be in the Kingdom of God. Tithing is not a suggestion but a command from God, which will bring tremendous blessings into your life.

Answer the following questions:

1. Have you and your future spouse discussed tithing? Write down the results of your discussion.

2. Are you and your future spouse in agreement about tithing?

3. Have you made a commitment to tithe?

As you are getting to know each other, you are probably finding that you have some different ways of doing things. One area where a difference can surface is in spending habits. You both have your own ideas and ways of spending money. You probably have different priorities for spending money - what you 'must' have and what is not so important. As a single person, you decided how you spent your money - on what, how much, and when. Now there are two of you to consider. Take the time to discuss your different spending habits and priorities. Good communication will build strength in this area.

Answer and discuss the following questions:

1. What are your priorities for spending money?

2. How does this compare to your future spouse's priorities?

3. What is your policy concerning the use of credit cards?

4. How does this compare to that of your future spouse's viewpoint?

5. Are you accustomed to having a spending allowance? Will you need to incorporate one into your finances?

6. What do you consider a major purchase? Do you feel you need to discuss all major purchases before they are made?

7. Discuss who will be responsible for what area of spending. (Not necessarily responsible for earning the money for that area, but for dispensing it.) For example: grocery money, gas money, monthly bills, tithe, entertainment, etc.

Write down the areas of responsibility and whose they are.

The last area we want to look at is that of a budget. Most couples and families find that they need to have a budget to help them keep their finances in order. You don't have to think of the word 'budget' as a confining word. Actually, it will bring you freedom by keeping you out of debt and eliminating the pressure of bill collectors. A budget enables you to have a clear idea of your income and expenses.

A budget can be a very simple thing - merely showing your monthly income and expenses, or for some families, it will be more complex. Your budget must be custom-built to fit your situation. The most important benefit of a budget comes when you use it and stay within its guidelines.

A basic budget will include all of your monthly expenses. In addition to that, you need to include tithe, giving and saving. A good rule of thumb is to tithe 10% and save 10%. Your giving is as you purpose in your heart; you give what you have, not what you don't have. If at all possible, your budget should also include some type of funds to be invested into your marriage relationship, whether it's for date nights, books, tapes, seminars, or whatever. Your marriage is worth the investment.

Answer and discuss the following questions:

1. Have you and your future spouse discussed a budget?

2. What agreement did you reach about it? (You want to be sure you can afford to be married.)

3. Write down your budget here:

4. Your budget should have a goal. What is your goal? What do you want to accomplish and attain, financially in the next five years? (Be realistic)

Keep your budget adjustable. You will not arrive at the perfect budget the first time. Periodically, you as a couple need to look at it and decide where adjustments need to be made. Discuss your budget together; always have it be open and accessible. Be open to discussion - remember, unity will bring strength.

God expects us to be wise with our finances. With wisdom comes increase. Proverbs 8:20-21 says, *"I [Wisdom, continuously] walk in the way of righteousness, In the midst of the paths of justice, That I may cause those who love me to inherit wealth and true riches, And that I may fill their treasuries.* Proverbs 10:4 says, *"He who deals with a slack hand becomes poor, but the hand of the diligent makes one rich."* God is for you, and His plan is for you to increase. When you walk in wisdom, diligence, and integrity, you'll walk in prosperity.